

FOLLOWING ITS SHOCK WIN IN THE FIRST TEST IN HYDERABAD, WHICH PROMPTED INDIA TO PREPARE PITCHES ON WHICH BATTING ISN'T A LOTTERY, IT HAS BEEN A CAMPAIGN OF 'WHAT IF'S' FOR ENGLAND



debut with a counter-attacking 66-ball 62 in Rajkot. A rare full-blooded sweeper of the ball, he brings a very different dimension to India's middle-order. His strike rate of 79.36, the second highest for India, belies his ability to pick his moments, which was on display in Dharamshala when he crawled to nine off 30 balls before rushing to a 55-ball fifty.

Dhruv Jurel's debut coincided with Sarfaraz's but was somewhat lost amidst the fanfare until he had his moment under the sun in Ranchi, first with a situation-defying 149-ball 90 and then a match-winning, unbeaten 39 in a nerve-battering run-chase. Drafted into the squad as

backup to a backup wicketkeeper, K.S. Bharat, Jurel's classical technique against spin makes him a solid No. 7 option, and his ability to bat with the tail means he can hold his own even as a specialist batter.

With Jasprit Bumrah rested for what turned out to be the series-clincher in Ranchi, Akash Deep's three-wicket haul in the opening burst on the first day was a testament to the quality of India's assembly line of pacers coming through the ranks in domestic cricket. With Akash hitting the deck hard at a good pace and probing away in the channel outside off, Bumrah's workload could be

Hunting the Three Lions: India thrashed England by an innings and 64 runs to seal a comprehensive 4-1 series victory in Dharamshala.

R.V. MOORTHY

managed without compromising too much on quality.

After a prolific Ranji Trophy season, Devdutt Padikkal showed he also belongs to the next level with a visually pleasing 65 in the final Test. He uses his range rather than feet to good effect against spin and unlocks a unique facet in a right-hander-heavy middle-order.

The impressive outings for the debutants came on the back of